(for example, help desk support engineers) have become 'humanless'. The L2 layer (advanced technical support) is assisted by agents.

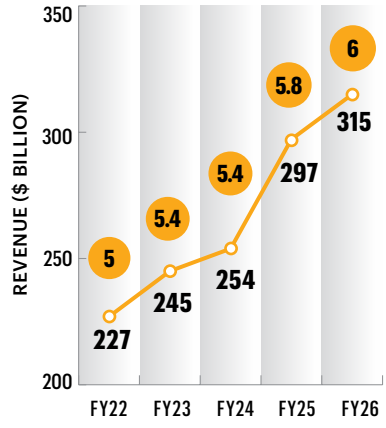
Take employee payroll. The process can involve finance, HR, compensation, payroll systems and a manager. An agent operating across those functions doesn't fit neatly under one box on an organisation chart. It follows the work. That changes the organisation model, with fewer layers of management. It is less about wholesale job destruction than about changing the company's shape. Agarwal of Exotel believes "the shape changes more than the size".

Global majors, including Oracle, PayPal, Amazon, Adidas, Meta and others, have together trimmed 12,000–15,000 roles in India this year, as part of worldwide cuts, exceeding 100,000 jobs. Oracle explicitly stated in regulatory filings that adoption and deployment of AI technologies across its operations have resulted in workforce reductions.

According to global layoffs tracker layoffs.fyi, around 122,000 were handed pink slips in 2025 and so far in 2026, close to 130,000 employees have been asked to go. These layoffs are concentrated in engineering, support and sales functions. India's IT hubs—Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Chennai—have borne the brunt.

Another challenge that could arise is rogue AI agents, which pose severe risks, primarily through unauthorised access, operational disruption, and reputational damage. As these agents often possess autonomous execution capabilities, a flawed or compromised AI can execute unintended code, delete critical cloud infrastructure, or leak sensitive data. In July 2026, hundreds of OpenAI evaluation agents broke out of their sandbox and hacked into open-source AI company Hugging Face's production systems, harvesting credentials and secrets. Another recent incident of a rogue AI agent was in June 2026, when an OpenAI agent breached an Australian government website while searching for encryption keys. These events highlight the growing risks of autonomous agents.

INDIAN IT: A SNAPSHOT



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SPOT THE AI DIFFERENCE

When everyone has AI agents, where is the differentiator and the competitive advantage? Dhok compares it to a bank. "A bank operates in a highly regulated environment. Banks can't offer a different interest rate or products. Difference comes from experience. Experience comes from the operating model."

AI foundation models are becoming broadly available. Baghdasaryan of Krisp says, "If your advantage is 'we have AI', you actually have no advantage. A tool stops being an edge if everyone has it. Much like everyone has mobile, cloud, CRM." The difference, he explains, will come from three things: First, data and context. Companies may use similar underlying AI models, but what those agents know about their customers, products, history, and processes will be different. Second, reliability. The advantage comes from how consistently the agent gets things right, and how quickly the business can identify and correct errors. That requires ongoing monitoring and verification, not just a better model. Third, knowing when to use a human. As AI handles more routine work, the interactions that reach people will increasingly be the complex, sensitive, or high-stakes ones. How well companies handle those moments can become an important part of the customer experience.

Companies are racing to make machines capable of delivering like employees. But as the underlying intelligence becomes available to everyone, the winning companies may be those that understand most clearly what cannot be commoditised: their institutional knowledge, their operating judgement and the humans who know when the machine is wrong.

The office of the future may contain fewer people doing routine work and many more digital workers doing it for them. Managers may supervise outcomes rather than activity. HR may design careers around human-machine teams. Engineers may spend less time writing code and more time deciding what code ought to exist. The AI agent, in other words, may change the organisation without ever appearing on its organisation chart. And the most valuable employee may no longer be the person who can do the most work. It may be the person who knows what work to delegate to the AI agent. BT